

830,000 m² of green land built over?

A newsroom's satellite estimate, tested against an independent land-cover model

THE CLAIM

“Nearly 830,000 square metres of nature and cropland have been built up in Malta between 2018 and 2023.”

Amphora Media, Green to Grey, 11 September 2026

The press is held to the same standard as everyone else.

Companion piece: “nearly 95%” of it was farmland.

VERDICT

LARGELY SUPPORTED

*Figure stands up,
probably low.*

SUPPORTED

LARGELY
SUPPORTED

NOT
SUBSTANTIATED

MISLEADING

CONTRADICTED

MAIN RESULTS

1.4 km²

Independent estimate

Net new built-up land first mapped in 2020–21, in a second 10 m land-cover model.

0.26%

Arithmetic checks out

Share of Malta's land; 116 pitches; a quarter to 0.3 of Comino.

65%

Mostly cropland

Independent data; 31% was shrub or grass. Amphora: nearly 95%.

Noisy

Single-year maps mislead

Built-up area swings by up to 27 km² from year to year; only consistent change counts.

#1

Highest land take in Europe

EEA, 2012–2018, as a share of country area: about 0.92 km² in Malta.

FAIR TO SAY

Amphora described its figure as conservative, and the independent data agree. The farmland share needs a stated basis.

WHAT WOULD SETTLE IT

☐ Amphora's map polygons.

☐ Basis of the 95% figure.

☐ Development-zone status.

☐ The 2006–2012 EEA figure.